LaunchPoint Event Guide

Venture Pitch Competition

The Venture Pitch is a comprehensive presentation that tests participants' ability to apply startup principles and business analysis in real-world market conditions. Students engage in a multi-week build phase, creating or developing a real or hypothetical company or product. Teams then complete an in-person presentation where they must demonstrate an understanding of the business need, competition, and market strategy.

Participants will develop critical skills in market research, problem solving, critical thinking, and how to create viable business models. This event challenges students to think like startup founders while articulating their decision-making process and defending their strategies under scrutiny from expert judges.

Event Overview

Event Type	In-Person Presentation
Team Size	2 – 5 members

Event Elements

Round	Format	Objective
Presentation	Live presentation of pitch deck Software: Google Slides or Microsoft PowerPoint Pitch one company or product (Open Note)	Present a startup company or product idea using real market data and entrepreneurial principles

Timing Structure

Phase	Duration	Requirements
Presentation	**7 minutes**	The team delivers their pitch covering all required sections. The timekeeper provides a 1-minute warning and then indicates when time is up. Participants must stop immediately.
Q&A	**3 minutes**	The judge asks questions to probe understanding and critical thinking. For teams of more than one, every team member must respond to at least one question.

Knowledge Areas

Participants should be prepared to demonstrate knowledge across the following areas:

• Business Model & Strategy	• Customer Value Proposition
• Market Analysis & Opportunity	• Go-to-Market Strategy
• Competitive Landscape	• Funding & Investment Fundamentals
• Problem Identification & Validation	• Risk Management & Mitigation

Required Competition Items

	Teams Must Provide	We Provide
Presentation	• At least one working device with internet access • Any presentation materials (notecards, printed notes, etc.) • Devices to access notes or scripts during the presentation • Visual aids, props, products (optional)	• Internet access • Projector/screen for pitch deck and visuals

Event Administration

Live Pitch Presentation

Student teams prepare structured and engaging pitch prior to the in-person competition. This should highlight the real or hypothetical business, covering the recommended areas in accordance with the investor-style rubric.

Objective: Teams develop and present a compelling business venture to a panel of judges, demonstrating entrepreneurial thinking and strategic planning. Competitors pitch their innovative ideas, defend their business models, and showcase their ability to identify market opportunities while addressing potential investor concerns.

Key Details

- Teams register online
- Pitch an original business idea (product, service, etc.)
- All team members must present and participate within the pitch

Strategic Considerations

As you build and develop your pitch, consider the following:

Before You Begin

- Define your venture idea in one clear, memorable sentence — if you can't explain it simply, refine it
- Identify a specific, urgent customer pain point with real evidence (interviews, research, personal experience)
- Research the competitive landscape thoroughly to understand what exists and where the gaps are
- Determine your first target customers — the specific people you will go after first
- Establish your unique value proposition and why customers would choose you over alternatives

Building Your Pitch

- Document the "why now" — what trends, technologies, or changes make this the right moment for your solution
- Research your market size: how big is the overall space and what realistic portion can you capture first?
- Identify your first customers specifically — not just a demographic, but real types of people with a real problem
- Decide how you will charge customers and why that pricing approach fits your product
- Build a go-to-market plan that names the actual steps, channels, or partners to get to your first sale
- Anticipate tough questions about competition, market size, and how you will actually make money

Research & Validation

- Talk to potential customers — don't assume you understand their pain without validation
- Look for evidence that supports your assumptions (market reports, customer interviews, competitor research)
- Understand both the problem and solution deeply — be able to explain why current solutions fall short
- Research comparable companies to understand what pricing models have worked in similar markets
- Identify what could go wrong and develop thoughtful risk mitigation strategies

Presentation Preparation

- Practice your pitch until it feels natural and conversational, not memorized
- Ensure all team members understand every aspect of the venture and can speak confidently to any section
- Prepare for Q&A by anticipating the challenging questions judges are most likely to ask
- Balance confidence with humility — acknowledge risks while demonstrating you have thought them through
- Time your pitch carefully to cover all rubric elements without rushing
- Develop clear, simple visuals that support your story rather than distract from it

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Preparing Your Presentation

Your presentation should tell the compelling story of your startup idea. Judges want to understand not just what you built, but why you built it and what you learned along the way.

> **Remember:** The biggest pitfall is a lack of storytelling. Sharing information is a first step, but getting the audience emotionally engaged in the story is what sets a pitch apart. A lot of coaching focuses on clarity in how information is presented — the storytelling and the clarity tend to go hand in hand.
> *— Mayank Mehta, Assistant Director of Entrepreneurial Education, iVenture Team*

What to Include in Your Presentation

Your 7-minute presentation should address the evaluation criteria outlined in the rubric. The sections below are all **recommended** — use them as your guide when building your slides.

#	Section	Questions to Address in Your Pitch
1	**Company Purpose** *Define the company/business in a single declarative sentence*	• What is your company and what does it do? (One clear sentence) • What specific customer pain are you addressing? • Why are current solutions inadequate?
2	**Problem** *Describe the customer's pain, current solutions and why they are inadequate*	• What specific pain or frustration does your target customer experience? • What solutions exist today — and why do they fall short? • What evidence do you have that this problem is real and urgent?
3	**Solution & Value Proposition** *Value proposition and how your solution makes the customer's life better*	• How does your solution solve the customer's problem? • What specific benefits does your solution provide? • How does your solution make the customer's life meaningfully better? • What makes your approach different or better than what exists?

#	Section	Questions to Address in Your Pitch
4	**Why Now?** *Where does your solution fit in historical trends? What trends make your solution possible?*	• What has changed recently — in technology, behavior, regulation, or culture — that makes this the right moment? • Why couldn't this have worked 5 years ago, or why is it more urgent today? • What trends are enabling or accelerating the need for your solution?
5	**Market Size & Customer Validation** *How big is the market? Who are your first customers?*	• What is your market size? (TAM, SAM, SOM with clear calculations) • Who is your beachhead segment and why did you choose them? • Who are your early adopters and what evidence shows they'll pay? • How large is the overall market — and what realistic slice can you capture first? • Who specifically are your first target customers? Name the type of person, not just a demographic.
6	**Competitive Understanding & Positioning** *Knowledge of competitive landscape and clear differentiation strategy*	• Who are your main competitors (direct and indirect)? • How do you differentiate from existing solutions? • What is your unique competitive advantage? • Why will customers choose you over alternatives?
7	**Business Model & Go-to-Market** *How does this charge customers? How will you actually reach and sign your first customers?*	• How does the business charge customers? (subscription, one-time purchase, service fee, etc.) • Why does that pricing model make sense for this product and customer? • What is your specific plan to reach first customers — name the channels, partners, or outreach tactics. • Walk through the actual steps from zero to first sale.

Important Reminders

For Participants

- **All team members must participate.** Every team member must respond to at least one question during the Q&A period.
- **Practice your presentation.** Seven minutes goes quickly. Practice multiple times to ensure smooth delivery and time management.
- **Be authentic.** Judges value honesty, self-awareness, and genuine learning over jargon or pretending you made no mistakes.

Allowed Materials

- Computers, tablets, or smartphones to access your presentation, notes, or scripts
- Notecards, printed notes, or other reference materials
- Visual aids or slideshow presentations (*Optional but Recommended*)
- Props or product (*Optional*)

Visual Aids & Slideshows

- PowerPoint or Google Slides should help organize your thoughts and make your presentation more engaging
- Keep visuals clear, simple, and focused on supporting your narrative, do not read directly from slides
- A projector and screen will be provided

Scoring and Evaluation

The total score for the event is 100 points, split across two weighted categories: Business Strategy & Presentation (70%) and Communication & Presentation (30%). Each of the 10 criteria is worth a maximum of 10 points.

For complete rubric and scoring details visit our website.

#	Criteria	What Judges Are Looking For	Max
I. Business Strategy & Presentation — 70 Points			
1	**Company Purpose & Problem Definition**	Clear company description, compelling customer pain, evidence of inadequate current solutions	**10**
2	**Solution & Value Proposition**	How your solution addresses the problem and creates meaningful customer value	**10**
3	**Market Timing & Opportunity (Why Now?)**	Understanding of why this moment is right and identification of enabling trends	**10**
4	**Market Size & Customer Validation**	How big the market is, who your first specific customers are, and evidence they would pay	**10**
5	**Competitive Understanding & Positioning**	Knowledge of the competitive landscape and a clear differentiation strategy	**10**
6	**Business Model & Go-to-Market Strategy**	How the business charges customers and a specific, realistic plan to reach first customers	**10**
7	**Communication & Professional Presence**	Clarity of articulation, team engagement, and quality of Q&A responses	**10**
II. Communication & Presentation — 30 Points			
1	**Clarity & Articulation**	Ideas expressed clearly and understandably; story engages the audience	**10**
2	**Professional Presence**	Confidence, poise, and engagement; all members participate meaningfully	**10**
3	**Q&A Responses**	Thoughtful, substantive responses; all members contribute during questioning	**10**
		Total Points	**100**

VENTURE PITCH — JUDGE'S EVALUATION RUBRIC

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Criteria	Exceeds Expectations (10–9)	Meets Expectations (8–7–6)	Below Expectations (5–4–3)	Little/No Value (2–1–0)	Score (0–10)
Business Strategy & Presentation — 70 Points					
Company Purpose *Define the company/business in a single declarative sentence*	Crystal clear, compelling company definition. Immediately understand what the company does and who it serves.	Clear company definition. The audience understands the business purpose.	Vague or overly complex definition. Takes effort to understand what a company does.	Unclear or absent company definition. The audience was confused about the basic purpose.	/10
Problem *Describe the customer's pain, current solutions and why they are inadequate*	Compelling articulation of customer pain with specific examples. Current solutions are clearly inadequate. The problem feels urgent and important.	Clear problem statement with reasonable evidence. Current solutions explained. The problem is understandable.	Problem stated but lacks clarity or evidence. Current solutions are not well explained. Urgency unclear.	Problem unclear or unconvincing. No evidence of customer pain. Fails to explain inadequacy of current solutions.	/10
Solution & Value Proposition *Value proposition and how your solution makes the customer's life better*	Exceptional value proposition that clearly addresses the problem. Solution benefits are compelling and specific.	Solid value proposition. The solution addresses the problem. Benefits are clear and reasonable.	Basic solution presented but value proposition is weak. Benefits are vague or generic.	The solution is unclear or doesn't address the stated problem. Value proposition absent or unconvincing.	/10
Why Now? *Where does your solution fit in historical trends? What trends make your solution possible?*	Sophisticated understanding of market timing. Compelling trends clearly enable this solution now.	Good understanding of timing. Identifies relevant trends that support the venture.	Basic timing rationale. Trends mentioned but connection is weak or generic.	Poor or no timing explanation. Doesn't demonstrate why now is the right time.	/10
Market Size & Customer Validation *How big is the market? Who are your first customers? TAM, SAM, SOM?*	Clear, well-researched estimate of the overall market and the realistic slice they can capture first. First target customers are specific and named.	Reasonable market size estimate with some research behind it. First target customers are identified.	Market size is vague or just a guess. Target customers are too broad.	No real sense of market size. No specific customer identified.	/10
Competitive Understanding & Positioning *Knowledge of competitive landscape and clear differentiation strategy*	Thorough competitive analysis. Key competitors clearly identified. Compelling differentiation and competitive advantage articulated. Explains convincingly why customers will choose this solution.	Reasonable competitive awareness. Main competitors identified. Differentiation explained with adequate reasoning.	Competitors mentioned but analysis is superficial. Differentiation is vague or unconvincing.	No meaningful competitive analysis. Unaware of existing solutions or unable to differentiate.	/10
Business Model & Go-to-Market *How does this charge customers? How will you actually reach and sign your first customers?*	Clearly explains how the business charges customers (subscription, one-time purchase, service fee, etc.) and why that pricing makes sense. Specific plan for reaching first customers — names channels, partners, or outreach tactics.	Explains how the business will charge for its product or service. Has a reasonable plan for reaching early customers, even if some steps are still general.	How the business makes money is unclear or doesn't fit the product. Plan to reach customers is vague — says 'social media' or 'word of mouth' without specifics.	No explanation of how the business charges or sustains itself. No plan for how to reach customers.	/10
				Business Strategy & Presentation Subtotal:	_____ / 70

Criteria	Exceeds Expectations (10–9)	Meets Expectations (8–7–6)	Below Expectations (5–4–3)	Little/No Value (2–1–0)	Score (0–10)
Communication & Presentation — 30 Points					
Clarity & Articulation *Ideas expressed clearly and understandably*	Exceptionally clear. Complex ideas explained simply and effectively. Story flows naturally and engages the audience throughout.	Clear communication. Ideas are well-expressed and easy to follow.	Generally clear with some confusion or unclear phrasing. Story loses audience at points.	Unclear communication. Difficult to understand the main points.	/10
Professional Presence *Confidence, poise, and engagement; all members participate*	Highly professional, confident, and engaging. All members contribute meaningfully. Presentation feels natural, not memorized.	Professional and appropriate. All members participate, though contributions may be uneven.	Generally professional with lapses. Not all members are fully engaged or contributing.	Unprofessional or one/some members don't participate meaningfully.	/10
Q&A Responses *Quality of responses; all members participate meaningfully*	Thoughtful, substantive responses to all questions. All members contribute meaningfully. Demonstrates deep understanding of the venture.	Good responses. All members participate, though contributions may be uneven. Shows solid understanding.	Basic responses. Not all members are fully engaged. Some questions answered poorly or avoided.	Unprofessional or weak responses. One/some members don't participate meaningfully.	/10
				Communication & Presentation Subtotal:	_____ / 30
				TOTAL POINTS:	_____ / 100